

52 PHYSICAL PLAY IDEAS

FROM
BIRTH



www.activecornwall.org

WHEN I PLAY,
I LEARN



PLAY BUILDS
CONNECTIONS IN
MY BRAIN



Date

IDEAS 1-4

My reflexes are important and I'm growing stronger every day.

1

What - allow your baby to rest on your chest on it's tummy and search for milk. You'll notice it's head bobbing up and down and it might shimmy it's way to your nipple.

Why - it strengthens it's neck and back muscles

2

What - move items across your baby's vision for it to focus on. Choose items with strong contrasting colours, like a soft toy, a book, a ball or a scarf.

Why - this helps your baby to focus it's eyes and to turn it's head.

3

What - sing and play gently in the bathtub together by either holding your baby or resting it on your tummy. Allow it to stretch out and play with the water.

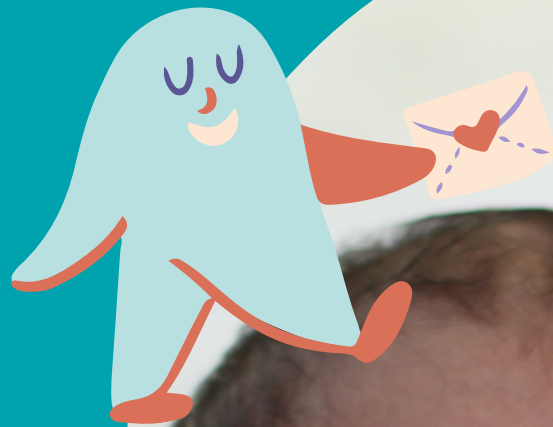
Why - babies love feeling different sensations, including warm water. Plus they will feel lighter and able to move more freely.

4

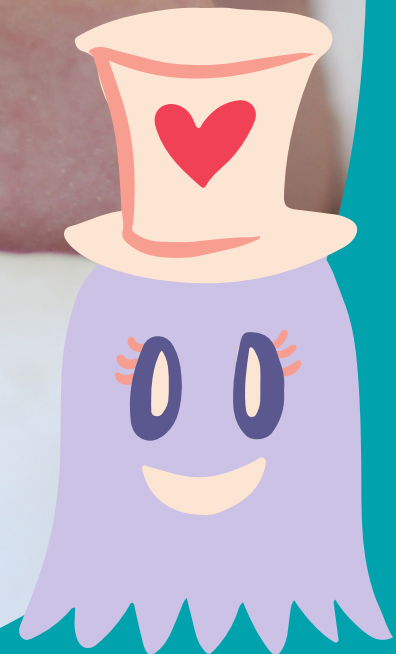
What - bring your face close to your baby's and coo and gurgle and change your facial expression

Why - your baby might start to respond and use it's facial expressions, start 'talking' and wave it's limbs about

I can....



I SHOULD BE DOING 30
MINUTES OF TUMMY
TIME A DAY (A FEW
MINUTES AT A TIME)





Date

IDEAS 5-8

I'm more alert and I can now focus my eyes and hear clearly.

5

What - hold baby in front of a mirror and move parts of your body, for example wave, lift your leg, shake your head. If your baby moves, try to copy it's movement.

Why - your baby is exploring it's movement and learning about cause and effect

6

What - lie your baby on it's tummy and place items in front to encourage your baby to reach out and grab

Why - this encourages your baby to lift it's head and reach it's arms, strengthening it's back, neck and arms as well as hand-eye coordination

7

What - sing and cycle your baby's legs and arms around while it's lying on it's back

Why - it strengthens their limbs as well as helping to massage their tummy and relieve constipation or gas

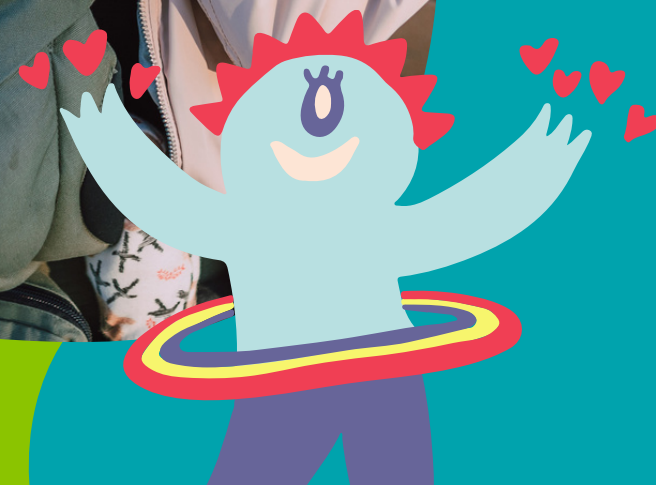
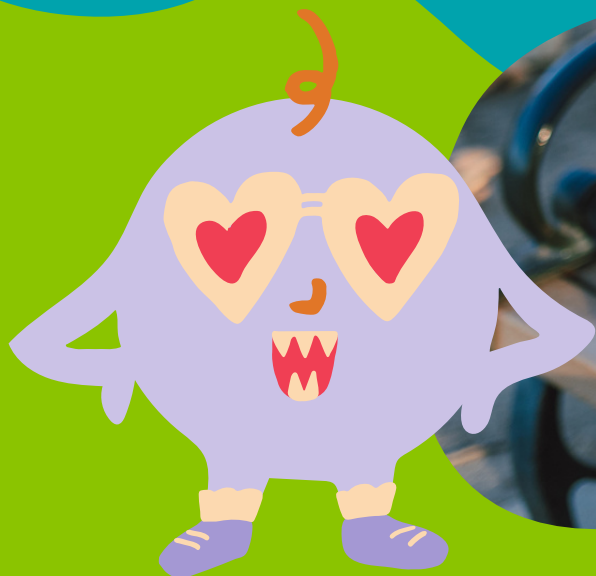
8

What - while your baby is lying on it's back, dangle items over it's head, such as string, ribbon, a shoelace, scarf, a toy

Why - your baby might reach out, get excited or wriggle about trying to touch it, which all helps build it's hand-eye coordination

I can....

I LOVE
MOTION,
WHITE NOISE
AND TO HEAR
YOUR HEART
BEAT



IDEAS 9-12

I'm a little nosy and love looking at high contrasting colours.

9

What - secure your baby in a front carrier and take them for a walk in some fresh air. Even 10 minutes is enough.

Why - your baby can hold it's head up a little more and will start looking alert. It's also great for their wellbeing and yours.

10

What - gather household items that make a noise and introduce your baby to different sounds, for example crumpled foil, a rattle, music, banging a wooden spoon etc

Why - your baby is learning about sounds and cause and effect

11

What - prop your baby up on pillows, or your legs, while safely supporting it's neck and move high contrasting coloured items in front of it's face

Why - this helps strengthen your baby's core and neck muscles while helping it focus it's eyes. It may also reach for them.

12

What - while your baby is lying in the pram, take it for a walk in a wooded area and allow it to see the different patterns branches make above it's head

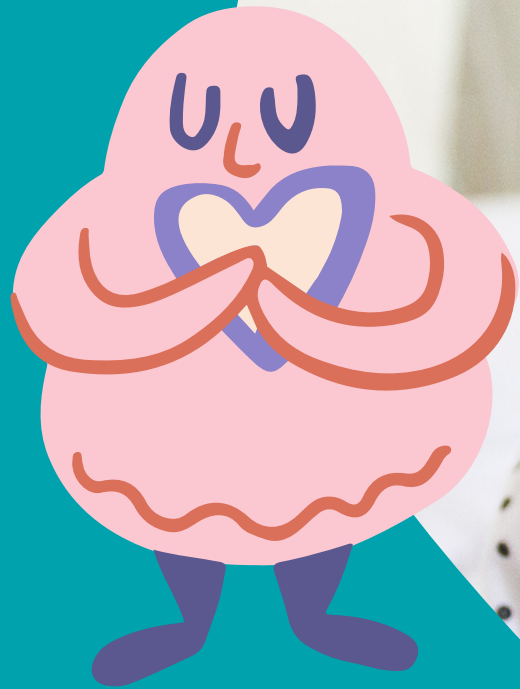
Why - your baby will start to focus and move it's body and head. It's also great for your wellbeing to get out in the natural environment.

I can....

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I NEED TIME TO MOVE
FREELY AND EXPLORE
MY GROWING WORLD



IDEAS 13-16

I am curious about the world around me.

13

What - give your baby time on a play mat to explore objects around them, such as toys, teether, teddies, dummies, ribbons, socks, mirrors etc
Why - your baby needs free time to explore and stretch it's limbs and build muscle

14

What - sing nursery rhymes and encourage your baby to move with the music, such as clapping their hands or waving their arms to 'pat-a-cake' or 'wheels on the bus'
Why - your baby is noticing it can move its body, make noises and it can help you bond

15

What - play your favourite music and dance around the kitchen with your baby in arms, moving it's arms and spinning it around, lifting them up and down
Why - this helps strengthen your baby's neck, back and limbs and listen to different sounds

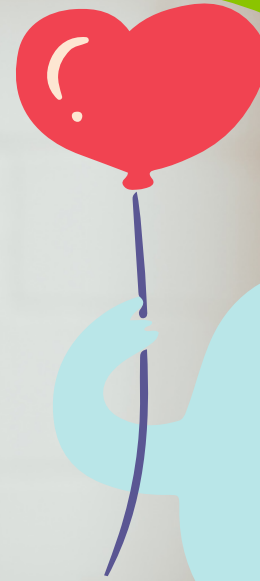
16

What - encourage more tummy time and play by placing your baby on different surfaces, such as a play mat, a carpet, towel, rug, crawling mat etc
Why - your baby will start trying to crawl and will lower itself up and down on it's arms. This strengthens it's body and makes it more interesting as it learns about new textures.

I can....

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EVERYTHING IS
AN ADVENTURE!



Date

IDEAS 17-20

I am getting stronger every day and might be able to sit up on my own!

17

What - grab a pot of bubbles and watch your baby laugh and interact with the falling bubbles as you blow.
Why - this helps your baby practise their hand-eye coordination

18

What - bounce your baby up and down in water and swirl them backwards and forwards, whether that's a pool or the bath.
Why - your baby will love the feeling of being light-weight and it helps to build muscle

19

What - bounce your baby up and down on your lap by encouraging it to bend it's legs and push off with it's feet
Why - this helps strengthen your baby's leg muscles, ready for crawling and walking

20

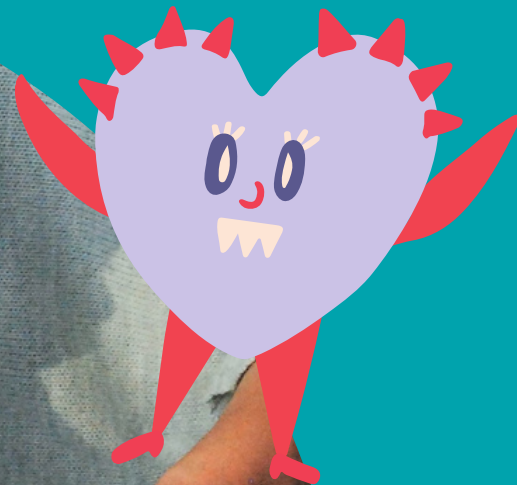
What - encourage your baby to sit upright, with your support
Why - your baby is strengthening it's core muscles and learning about balance

I can....

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PLAY TIME
IS IMPORTANT
FOR MY
DEVELOPMENT





Date

IDEAS 21-24

My language skills are developing every day.

21

What - while in a pool or a bath splash baby with water gently and say 'splash' in a sing-song voice. Encourage baby to splash and have fun.

Why - this helps your baby with gross motor skills and cause and effect

22

What - encourage your baby to roll by rolling baby onto it's side, while fully supported, and rolling back. Talk as you do it and explain you are rolling.

Why - your baby is building side muscles and learning how to roll

23

What - take a walk with baby and point out the world around it. Allow baby to touch leaves, grass, dirt, sand and stretch and reach.

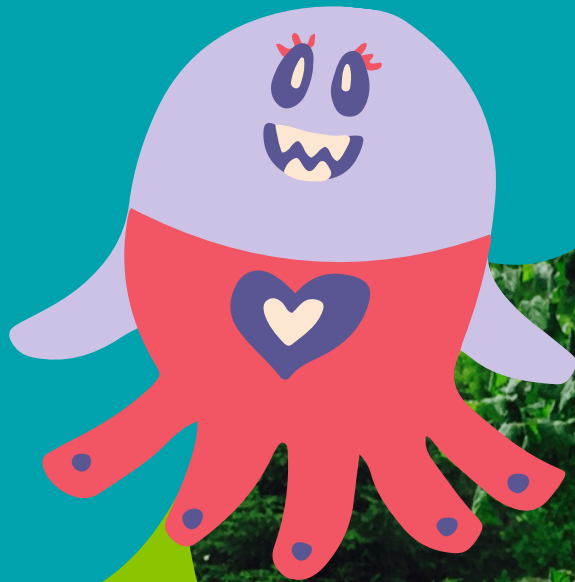
Why - encourages your baby to reach, stretch and feel new textures

24

What - read your baby's favourite book and encourage baby to turn pages, lift flaps, spin it around and generally play with pages.

Why - this supports your baby's fine motor skills as well as reading and language skills

I can....



YOUR VOICE RELAXES
ME, PLEASE SING TO ME



Date

IDEAS 25-28

Singing is an important part of my language development.

25

What - sing nursery rhymes while moving your baby's hands to the music. For example, wheels on the bus, row row row your boat and down in the jungle.

Why - this helps your baby learn new body movements and language

26

What - place items on your baby's high chair and encourage them to push them off and clap afterwards.

Why - your baby is learning cause and affect as well as practising hand-eye coordination

27

What - hide items under a blanket and watch as your baby learns to lift the blanket to find the items

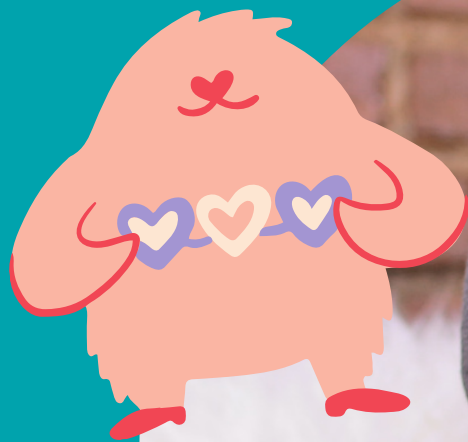
Why - a mix of fine and gross motor skills as well as learning about object permanence

28

What - bounce your baby up and down on your lap by encouraging it to bend it's legs and push off with it's feet

Why - this helps strengthen your baby's leg muscles, ready for crawling and walking

I can...



YOU ARE MY
FAVOURITE TOY



IDEAS 29-32

I am becoming more independent but you are still my security.

29

What - encourage your baby to eat with finger food, such as cucumber sticks, banana pieces or breadsticks.
Why - this helps your baby develop fine motor skills and hand-eye coordination

30

What - lie on your back and lift your baby up and down in the air while pulling funny faces
Why - helps your baby control it's body while moving and start to copy your facial expressions

31

What - place items that roll in front of your baby while it's on it's tummy and encourage your baby to roll them backwards and forwards
Why - this strengthens your baby's arms, back and neck muscles

32

What - choose small items and a large bucket and help your baby to move items from one bucket to another. Talk to our baby about how the object feels, or what colour it is, or count the items
Why - this supports your baby's fine motor and gross motor skills. Adding words supports language development.

I can....

I SHOULD BE
ACTIVE
SEVERAL
TIMES
THROUGHOUT
THE DAY



IDEAS 33-36

I crawl (or bum shuffle) therefore I am.

33

What - if your baby is crawling, play a game of crawl chase and watch your baby squeal with excitement as they copy you
Why - this encourages your baby to crawl for fun and for play

34

What - if weather is dry, allow your baby to crawl on grass and pick at the blades
Why - your baby is learning about the world as well as adjusting it's body to different surfaces

35

What - take your baby to the beach or park where it can play in sand and encourage your baby to make shapes in the sand
Why - your baby is learning cause and effect as well as fine motor skills

36

What - sit across from your baby and roll a ball towards your baby to encourage it to roll it back
Why - this supports your baby's hand-eye coordination as well as encourages turn taking

I can....

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BEING BAREFOOT
BUILDS MUSCLES
IN MY FEET SO I
CAN WALK

IDEAS 37-40

My legs and core are getting stronger everyday.

37

What - if your baby can stand, encourage them to stand and sit repeatedly by placing toys on a table or sofa and on the floor.

Why - your baby is learning how to sit down and stand up as well as balance

38

What - fill old plastic bottles with rice, or pasta or buttons and encourage your baby to shake them around - even better if to music

Why - this develops your baby's rhythm, stability and coordination
(make sure bottles are sealed)

39

What - hold your baby by the waist or hands and pretend walk them around the room

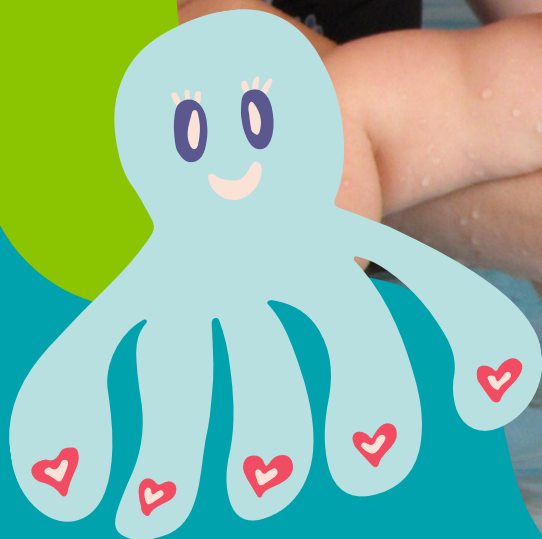
Why - this helps you baby to practice stepping without their body weight

40

What - make funny sounds by blowing into objects or patting your lips while exhaling and watch as your baby copies

Why - this helps your baby's hand-eye coordination as well as their focus

I can....



PLAYING IS MY
WAY OF LEARNING

IDEAS 41-44

I can understand more than I can say.

41

What - pretend to be a tunnel by standing with legs wide apart and encourage your baby to crawl through while you say 'choo choo'

Why - your baby is learning spatial awareness

42

What - give your baby chunky crayons to hold and show them how to colour on paper and watch as they try to copy. Or you could use yoghurt and their fingers to 'paint'

Why - this develops fine motor skills and you can encourage learning about colours

43

What - take your baby to the nearest park and have fun on the swings, try to get your baby to tap your hands or move their feet and hold on to the bar

Why - this builds on gross motor skills such as stability, hand strength and coordination

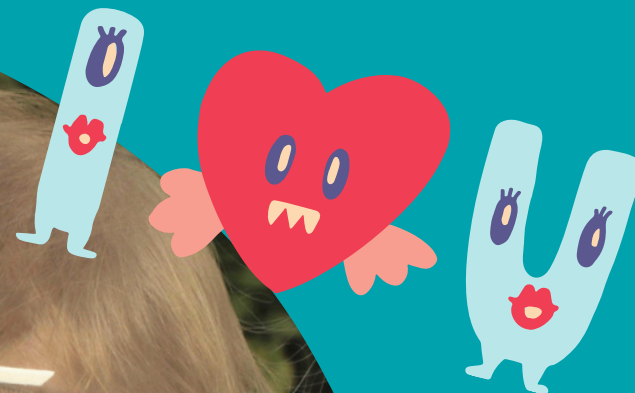
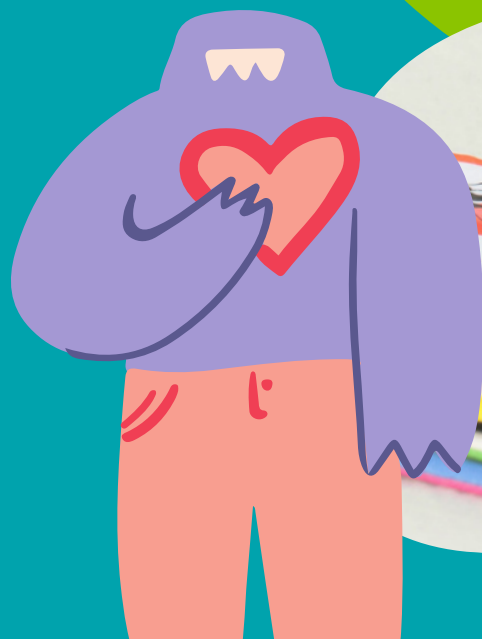
44

What - whether in a pool or the bath, have some time splashing in water and move floating toys about

Why - this helps build muscle and gets them confident in water play

I can....

I WILL GET
THERE IN MY
OWN TIME, BUT
I NEED YOUR
HELP



IDEAS 45-48

We all develop at different stages: I will get there.

45

What - play the drums with wooden spoons and pans/plastic bowls. Make noise and get whacking.

Why - this helps gross motor development and cause and effect

46

What - let your baby choose their favourite book and encourage them to 'read' it by turning the pages and tapping pictures or lifting flaps. As they make sounds 'reply' to them with words so that they begin to learn about taking turns in a conversation.

Why - they are developing fine motor skills and language

47

What - using dried penne pasta and a shoe lace, encourage your baby to thread the lace through the pasta. Or use an old box, cut holes in it and 'post' objects through.

Why - this helps with fine motor skills and patience!

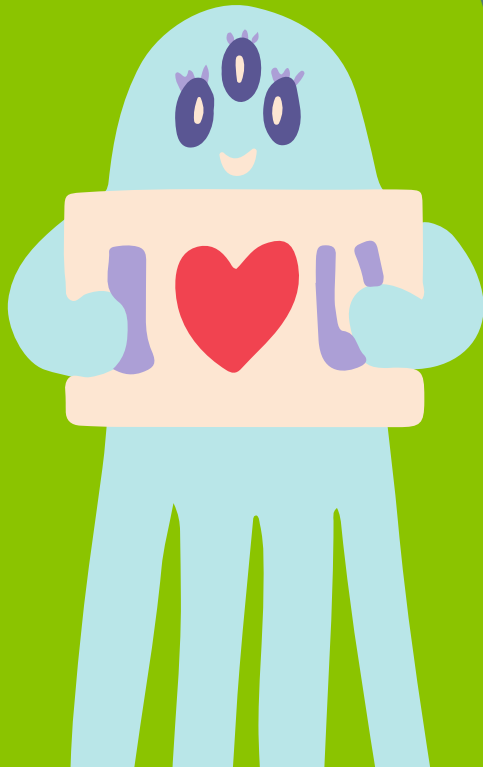
48

What - if your baby can stand and is walking with help, encourage them to walk around furniture by putting toys along like a treasure trail, then get them to put them in a bucket

Why - this helps build their confidence and strength in their legs as well as core strength

I can....

BEST
YEAR
EVER





Date

IDEAS 49-52

We made it! Thank you for playing with me.

49

What - choose toys that can roll or move and race them across your floor, then encourage your baby to crawl after them and bring them back

Why - this helps your baby to take turns and control objects possibly

50

What - if your baby is standing, try placing items slightly out of reach to encourage them to stretch and stand on tip tops

Why - they are strengthening muscles in their feet

51

What - if you have access to lots of small balls or blocks, have a game of target practice by throwing the items into a box or bucket and count as you do it.

Why - this helps throwing but also distances and coordination.

52

What - buy your baby some birthday balloons and watch as they throw, bounce, squeeze or hit them around the room.

Why - gross motor development plus a little bit of a celebration!

I can....

MY FIRST YEAR OF ACTIVITY

My favourite games were...

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Chief Medical Officer Guidelines

- Infants should be **physically active several times every day** in a variety of ways, including floor-based activity, e.g. crawling.
- For infants not yet mobile, this includes at least **30 minutes of tummy time spread throughout the day** while awake (and other movements such as reaching and grasping, pushing and pulling themselves independently, or rolling over); more is better.
- **Every baby develops at different stages.** If your baby is not ready for some of the activities, that's okay. You can revisit another time.

NB: Tummy time may be unfamiliar to babies at first, but can be increased gradually, starting from a minute or two at a time, as the baby becomes used to it.

Further ideas:

- Activities for babies, toddlers and children - BBC Tiny Happy People - <https://www.bbc.co.uk/tiny-happy-people>
- Weaning Recipes & Meal Ideas | Start for Life (www.nhs.uk) - <https://www.nhs.uk/start4life/weaning/recipes-and-meal-ideas/>
- Active Start: Ideas, activities and tips to raise an active child - Active For Life - <https://activeforlife.com/active-start/>

Safety: Babies should not sleep on their tummies. Babies should not be left alone with dangling cords or ribbons that could tie around their neck or limbs. They should not be left alone with items they could swallow and choke.